

PROSPER IN AMERICA

*The*

# Orlando Insider Guide

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*Curated places from a local  
who drives them every day.*

CURATED BY JOHN DAVID

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A PROSPER IN AMERICA GUIDE · DESIGNED BY GO BIG

WELCOME

# A Florida worth knowing.

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I drive Orlando every day. I've picked up thousands of visitors at the airport, dropped them at every theme park, every springs trail, every Brazilian restaurant in town.

These are the places I send my own family. No tourist traps. No paid placements. Just what I'd tell a friend who flew in for the week.

— *John David*

ONE

# The Springs

*The Florida nobody plans for, and the Florida everyone remembers.*

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## Blue Springs State Park

35 MIN NORTH · \$6 PER CAR

72°F all year. Manatees from November to March, dozens at a time from a boardwalk. Get there by 9 AM in winter or it fills up.

## De Leon Springs

45 MIN NORTH · \$6 PER CAR

Flip your own pancakes at the Old Spanish Sugar Mill, then swim in the spring next door. A real Florida day.

## Rock Springs at Kelly Park

40 MIN NORTH · ENTRY FEE + TUBE RENTAL

Rent a tube and float a one-mile spring-fed run that ends in a swimming hole. Pure Florida. Get there before 11 AM on weekends or they cap entries.

TWO

# Beaches Worth the Drive

*Two coasts to choose from. Both about an hour out.*

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## New Smyrna Beach

1 HR EAST · EAST COAST

Less crowded than Daytona. You can drive on the beach. Best swim and sunset combo on the east coast.

## Cocoa Beach

45 MIN EAST · EAST COAST

Surf rentals, the famous Ron Jon shop, classic Florida boardwalk feel. Good for a half-day.

## Clearwater Beach

1.5 HR WEST · GULF COAST

White sand, calmer water, gulf side. If your visit lines up with sunset, drive west.

THREE

# Towns to Wander

*Walking towns. Lake views. A different pace than the parks.*

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## Mount Dora

45 MIN NORTHWEST · FREE

Charming small town on a lake. Antique shops, lakefront dining, lake cruise if you like.

## Winter Park

15 MIN FROM DOWNTOWN · FREE

Right inside Orlando but feels like its own world. Park Avenue shops, brick streets, the Morse Museum if you like Tiffany glass.

## Winter Garden

30 MIN WEST · SATURDAY IS THE MOVE

The Saturday morning farmers market is the move. Park downtown, walk the brick streets, grab a coffee, watch families ride the West Orange Trail.

## FOUR

# Brazilian Comfort

*For when you miss home.*

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## Seabra Foods

GROCERY · BUTCHER · PAY-BY-THE-POUND BUFFET

Brazilian grocery, butcher, and pay-by-the-pound hot lunch buffet — my favorite, weigh and eat. Real cuts for churrasco, products straight from Brazil. The community spot when you miss home.

## Camilla's

BRAZILIAN RESTAURANT

Feijoada on weekends, picanha any day, Brazilian breakfast. Authentic, warm, a favorite for families.

## First Orlando Church — Brazilian Campus

SUNDAYS 9 AM · FREE BREAKFAST BEFORE SERVICE

Brazilian Sunday service. Arrive at 9 AM for free breakfast before the service. A real community welcome.

## God of Promises Church

SUNDAY EVENINGS 6 PM

Smaller, intimate, vision-driven. If you're looking for a church, both of these are home to me.

FIVE

# Theme Parks, the Honest Take

*Most of what you read is sponsored. Here's what I'd actually tell a friend.*

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## Magic Kingdom (Disney)

WORTH IT ONCE

Get there at park-open, hit the headliners before 11 AM, take a midday break at the hotel pool, come back for the fireworks. One day, not three.

## Universal Studios + Islands of Adventure

BETTER FOR ADULTS AND OLDER KIDS

Better park experience than Disney for adults and older kids. Harry Potter is the reason. Buy the Express Pass if your budget allows — saves 4-5 hours of waiting.

## Volcano Bay

BEST WATER PARK IN ORLANDO

The best water park in Orlando. Better than Disney's. Half-day in summer.



# Disney Springs

## SKIP THE "PARK" FRAMING

It's a shopping and restaurant complex, not an experience. Worth a 2-hour evening visit for a meal and a wander, not a destination.

SIX

# Where to Stay

*If you have flexibility on lodging, this matters more than you think.*

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## Windsor Island Resort

DAVENPORT · 25 MIN FROM THE PARKS

Where I stay when family visits. Gated, high security, full resort with a water park, lazy river, gym, restaurant. Quieter than the Disney hotels and roughly half the price for what you get.

# Practical

*The stuff a guide usually skips.*

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## Driving

Orlando is car-dependent. Toll roads everywhere. Get a SunPass or pay the rental car's toll plan. Google Maps underestimates traffic between 4 PM and 7 PM. Add 30%.

## Weather

Summer rain comes daily at 3 PM, lasts 30 minutes. Don't cancel your plans. Just get under cover for a beat.

## Tipping

20% standard at restaurants. \$2-5 per bag at hotels. Rideshare: anything is appreciated, nothing is required.

## Language

Most of the service industry in Orlando speaks Spanish and a fair amount of Portuguese. Brazilian restaurants always speak Portuguese. Spanish or English will get you anywhere.

## Common scams

Three to watch for: anyone selling "discount tickets" near park gates — walk away. Timeshare presentations promising free park tickets — your

morning vanishes for tickets you could have bought online for less.  
Rideshare drivers quoting flat rates off-app — always book in-app.

EIGHT · STAY IN TOUCH

# Until next time.

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## BUILDING SOMETHING WHILE YOU'RE HERE

Brand or site help.

*[prosperinamerica.com/go-big](https://prosperinamerica.com/go-big)*

— *John David*